1 Adjectives: Interrogative and Emphasizing

In Book 4, you were told about three kinds of adjectives: *qualitative, quantitative* and *demonstrative*. We shall now look at two more kinds of adjectives: ***interrogative*** and ***emphasizing***.

Interrogative Adjectives

An interrogative adjective is used with a noun that it qualifies to ask a question:

(a) Which part of the world do you come from?

(b) What gifts did you get on your birthday?

(c) Whose books are those on the table?

In *(a)*, *which* qualifies the noun *part* and also asks a question.

In *(b)*, *what* qualifies the noun *gifts* and also asks a question.

In *(c)*, *whose* qualifies the noun *books* and also asks a question.

(See also Chapter 17, pp 99–102)

Emphasizing Adjectives

1. Sometimes, we use adjectives to *emphasize* or *heighten* the effect of what we say:

   (d) What the man said was absolute rubbish.

   (e) Rita came late and had to stand at the very end of the line.

   (f) The book was a total failure, for only a few people bought it.

   (g) Jack built this house with his own hands.

In *(d)*, the word *absolute* qualifies the noun *rubbish*. It has been used to emphasize the worthlessness of what the man said; it was not only rubbish, but *absolute* rubbish.

Similarly, *(e)* tells us that Rita came late and had to stand not only at the end of the line, but at the *very* end of it. The word *very* qualifies the noun *end*.

Sentence *(f)* describes how great a *failure* the book was. It was not just a failure, it was a *total* failure. The word *total* qualifies the noun *failure*.

In *(g)*, the speaker wants to make it clear how hard Jack had worked to build the house. So, the word *own*, though not necessary, has been used for the sake of emphasis, and qualifies the noun *hands*.

2. Sometimes, adjectives are used not to heighten, but to *lower* the effect of what the noun it qualifies would make us expect:

   (h) After the storm, there was a slight fall in the temperature.

   (i) When she heard the good news, she gave a feeble smile.

   Sentence *(h)* says that the temperature did not fall as much as expected after the storm; there was only a *slight* fall.

   Similarly, in *(i)*, the smile is only *feeble*; she did not express as much joy at the good news as was expected.

Mention of what kind each of the underlined adjectives is:

1. 'Do not listen to what Ravi says, for he is a complete fool,' said Rohan.
2. Kiran is a great supporter of non-violence.
3. 'What crime has the prisoner committed?' asked the judge.
4. Aurangzeb had his own father, Shah Jahan, imprisoned in the Agra Fort.
5. The play was an utter failure and the actors were booed by the audience.
6. Whose book is that lying on the table?
7. He spent his entire fortune and built a hospital for the villagers.
8. The simple truth is that Jim cannot run as fast as he thinks.
9. What he said is an outright lie, and he should be punished severely for it.
10. 'Which game are you best at?' asked Javed.